Introduction

When the first railway lines and steam-puffing locomotives were seen moving on this land, it caused a stir in what was a traditional and culturally-rich society. It led to surprise, fear, superstition, gossip and awe. With the fascination for speed and locomotion, acceptance for this ‘new’ technology came in slowly, with caution, but eventually, completely. And amidst this clash of cultures sprung fascinating tales of people, the changing social life of the country’s remote villages and the people’s journeys. This book is about those tales—tales that made Indian Railways what it is today, tales that look at its legacy, growth and development.

This work, a compilation of anecdotes and sketches of the Indian Railways, was first suggested to me by Rupa Publications’ CEO, Shri Kapish Mehra. It took more time than expected to bring it to fruition. It involved collating the right anecdotes from numerous sources, building research around them and ground work—from visiting India’s oldest functional station at Chennai to tracking down one of the key team members behind the subcontinent’s first superfast train, the Rajdhani Express —and then documenting all of them chronologically. There were numerous ups and downs throughout the process, and at the end of it, I started building a narrative to weave the stories together, thanks to the persistent editor Shri Rudra Sharma who kept suggesting improvizations to the draft to mould it into what has now turned out to be, hopefully, a fabulous book.

The research was not without its own set of challenges. While in some cases there was a multiplicity of sources, some anecdotes were closer to fiction, a few had authentication problems and others had vague narratives and unclear data. Narrowing down from among these to select a few great